

Retreating falls

Waterfalls retreat upstream as the caprock is eroded. The edge of the basalt cap of Iguazu Falls is receding by $\frac{1}{8}$ in (3 mm) a year.

**◀ IGUAZU RIVER**

The Iguazu River is one of the major tributaries of the Paraná River, South America's second longest river after the Amazon, which it joins 14 miles (23 km) downstream of the falls.

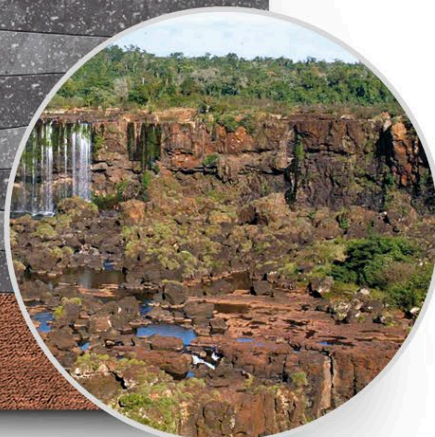
viewing gallery on Argentine side of falls

◀ GREAT WATER

Iguazu Falls is about three times the width of North America's Niagara Falls (see p.52) and around 50 percent taller. The name of the falls and river is from a word in the indigenous Guaraní language that translates as "great water."

Atlantic Forest

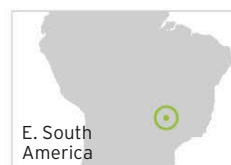
The tropical forest surrounding the falls is a remnant of the once vast Atlantic Forest. The Iguazu National Park protects the thousands of species of plants and animals living within its borders.



top layers of hard rock

△ DROUGHT-AFFECTED FALLS

Waterfalls can experience great fluctuations in water flow. During the dry season, when long-periods of droughts may occur, Iguazu Falls can shrink to a fraction of its size, completely transforming its appearance.



Iguazu Falls

One of the world's greatest waterfall systems, situated within a lush South American tropical forest

Spanning part of the border between northeastern Argentina and southern Brazil, Iguazu Falls is one of the largest waterfall systems on Earth, rivaled in size only by Africa's Victoria Falls (see pp.194–95). It is located on a tight horseshoe bend of the Iguazu River and drops a total of 269 ft (82 m).

Complex system

Iguazu Falls is a vast and complex series of up to 300 separate waterfalls—depending on the water level of the river—stretching $1\frac{3}{4}$ miles (2.7 km) along a fragmented basalt escarpment. Above the falls, many islands split the river into the flows that feed the waterfalls, which vary in size. At the heart of the falls is the Devil's Throat, a narrow, semicircular chasm down which half of the river's waters plunge. Iguazu Falls produces huge clouds of spray that constantly soak the surrounding area, creating a humid microclimate in which a diverse group of plants and animals flourish.

HOW A WATERFALL FORMS

Waterfalls form where a river flows from hard to softer rock. The water erodes the soft rock faster than the hard rock, creating a step then a plunge pool. Undercut sections of the hard rock eventually collapse, and as this process continues, the waterfall retreats upstream.

